

Checklist:

The Right Team

1. First Product Hire READINESS

- ☐ Founder no longer has enough time for product management work.
- ☐ Engineering may be working on the wrong priorities or unclear priorities.
- ☐ Team has around 5+ engineers.
- ☐ Company is launching or planning a second product.
- ☐ First hire is likely a **senior product manager**, not a VP/CPO too early.
- ☐ Role scope, decision rights, and boundaries are clearly defined.

2. First Product Hire EVALUATION

Look for a strong **product mindset**, including:

- ☐ Customer empathy
- ☐ Curiosity
- ☐ Humility
- ☐ Adaptability
- ☐ Intelligence
- ☐ Data-driven decision-making
- ☐ Continuous improvement
- ☐ Scrappiness
- ☐ Self-directed learning
- ☐ Accountability for outcomes
- ☐ Persistence and refusal to quit

3. Hiring PROCESS

- ☐ Give every serious PM candidate a homework assignment.
- ☐ Use a real business/product challenge, not a generic puzzle.
- ☐ Keep the assignment reasonable: roughly 2-3 hours.

- ☐ Use the assignment to test thinking, tradeoffs, data needs, and product judgment.
- ☐ Discuss the assignment in the interview.
- ☐ Ask why they made specific decisions.
- ☐ Ask what data they would collect.
- ☐ Ask what they would cut from an MVP under time pressure.
- ☐ Check whether they want to do the actual work your company needs.

4. SECOND Product Hire

- ☐ Hire a second PM when launching a new product or when one PM cannot cover the full scope.
- ☐ Consider a junior PM or APM if the first PM is senior.
- ☐ Balance the team with different experience levels, communication styles, and strengths.
- ☐ Do not add a product executive too early.
- ☐ Consider VP/Head of Product only when there is an MVP, paying customers, multiple PMs, and the founder is ready to delegate product strategy.

5. DESIGN Function

- ☐ Separate design from product management as soon as the company can afford it.
- ☐ Clarify UX responsibilities: usability, user research, workflows, mental models, task completion.
- ☐ Clarify UI/visual design responsibilities: look and feel, brand consistency, style systems, interaction patterns.
- ☐ Avoid having designers report into individual PMs once the design team grows.
- ☐ Ensure product and design have a peer relationship and collaborate closely.

6. Team SCALING Ratios

For each product team, roughly plan for:

- ☐ 5–7 developers
- ☐ 1 product manager
- ☐ 0.5 UX designer
- ☐ 0.3 UI/visual designer
- ☐ 1–2 QA engineers

Also:

- ☐ Hire PMs ahead of expected engineering growth.
- ☐ Make ownership and responsibility lines explicit.
- ☐ Over-communicate who owns roadmap decisions, technical debt prioritization, bugs, performance issues, and customer-facing outcomes.

7. Product MANAGER vs. Product OWNER

- ☐ Product manager owns market opportunity, customer needs, competitive landscape, success metrics, strategy, and prioritization.
- ☐ Product owner, if used, helps engineering with requirements, acceptance criteria, backlog management, standups, and development issues.
- ☐ Avoid splitting responsibility in a way that creates telephone games.
- ☐ Avoid removing PMs too far from customers.
- ☐ Ensure one person has real accountability for product outcomes.

8. Product OPERATIONS

Consider product ops when the org is larger or more mature.

- ☐ Centralize repeatable product processes.
- ☐ Maintain product documentation.
- ☐ Organize roadmap input from stakeholders.
- ☐ Manage product tools and systems.
- ☐ Track product management efficiency metrics.
- ☐ Maintain dashboards.
- ☐ Train new PMs.
- ☐ Create knowledge-sharing systems.
- ☐ Enforce release, stakeholder, and launch policies.
- ☐ Help PMs focus on strategy and customer outcomes.

9. Org STRUCTURE Choice

Choose how to organize product teams based on your company's needs:

- ☐ By product
- ☐ By feature
- ☐ By technical layer
- ☐ By customer segment/persona

- ☐ By customer journey stage
- ☐ By performance metric

Before choosing, ask:

- ☐ Does this maximize team autonomy?
- ☐ Does it minimize dependencies?
- ☐ Does it reduce negative effects of Conway's Law?
- ☐ Does each PM have clear jurisdiction?
- ☐ Does the structure match the product's life cycle stage?
- ☐ Will the structure improve customer outcomes and business results?

10. Healthy Product CULTURE

Create a culture where teams can do excellent product work.

- ☐ Dedicate time to customer discovery.
- ☐ Focus on collaboration.
- ☐ Delegate decision-making.
- ☐ Emphasize diversity.
- ☐ Define culture as everyday employee behavior, not slogans.

11. Customer DISCOVERY

Make sure PMs have direct contact with customers.

- ☐ Attend or conduct usability studies.
- ☐ Join sales calls.
- ☐ Join customer check-ins or QBRs.
- ☐ Conduct site visits.
- ☐ Interview lost or missed opportunities.
- ☐ Build a product advisory board.
- ☐ Avoid relying solely on sales or customer success as proxies for customers.
- ☐ Ask follow-up questions to understand motivations, not just feature requests.

12. COLLABORATION and Feedback

- ☐ Run simple 360-degree feedback for PMs.
- ☐ Ask: "On a scale of 1-5, how am I doing as a PM?"
- ☐ Ask: "What am I doing well?"
- ☐ Ask: "What could I be doing better?"

- ☐ Build trust through clear reasoning and alignment to vision and strategy.
- ☐ Optimize for effectiveness, not merely for being liked.

13. DELEGATED Decision-Making

- ☐ Push decisions down to individual contributors where possible.
- ☐ Give PMs clear KPIs and context.
- ☐ Remove roadblocks.
- ☐ Give people space, time, tools, and resources to understand problems deeply.
- ☐ Avoid a command-and-control culture.
- ☐ Encourage thoughtful innovation.

14. DIVERSITY and Team Composition

- ☐ Actively invest in diversity across gender, race, age, socioeconomic background, religion, sexual orientation, experience, personality, and perspective.
- ☐ Build a mix of business, design, and technical backgrounds.
- ☐ Avoid hiring only for narrow “culture fit.”
- ☐ Ask: “Which candidate adds something our team does not already have?”
- ☐ Ask: “Who best increases our collective ability to achieve outcomes for customers?”
- ☐ Treat culture fit as extending the team’s ability to live its values, not social similarity.